Intro
Social media, over the last fifteen years, has shifted from a platform intended to connect with family and friends to one of the largest media distribution platforms on the planet. Turning into a powerful tool for advertising companies that don't use social media advertising is left behind.

In the same way, the industry of gambling has changed - the casino used to be a physical location, visited with intention and operating in cash. In today's modern world, as everything moves online, so too have casinos, now accessible anywhere, anytime from your phone, with instantaneous, seamless transactions. The landscape of gambling and who it reaches has changed drastically. As these digital casinos look to expand to new customer bases, they too have turned to social media to promote their product.

My initial research question of: "How has social media impacted the expanding online gambling industry, specifically in relation to predatory practices targeting impressionable populations?" has shifted slightly. Over the course of my research, information was not abundant on vulnerable populations in general, while certain populations, such as recovering addicts or indigenous peoples, are groups susceptible to problem gambling, online information was overwhelmingly about youth demographics. For this reason, I pivoted my research to focus on youth and minors and their exposure to gambling.
My new research question is: How has the promotion of the expanding online gambling industry contributed to the increase in gambling rates among young people?

My findings indicate that through social media use, youth and underage users are exposed to gambling content as social media algorithms display content designed to retain engagement. This literature review displays how social media contributes to the growing issue of youth problem gambling. Analysing social media algorithms, modes of advertisement and a growing sentiment of gambling normalisation.

1. Social Media and Vulnerable Demographics

1.1 Social Media Algorithmic Capabilities

Social media websites present two standard types of content: user-chosen content eg, accounts that a person has followed or interacted with, and recommended content, which is chosen by the social media algorithm and is often adjacent to existing interests. Outlined in the paper, "Uncovering the interaction Equation" social media algorithms track content that users like, share and interact with. (Habib et al., 2024) While different social media sites track different metrics based on the style of content presented, they all track and utilise data. This data is used for marketing purposes to create a "profile" of what content users enjoy.

In a study by Kosinski, Stillwell and Graepel performed in 2013, where over 58,000 volunteers provided their Facebook Likes, from this data, a model was created that was able to predict personal details. Their model was able to successfully predict eleven elements at a success rate ranging from 60% to 95%. In fact, the model could predict a user's gender, race, religion and political affiliation at an over 80% success rate.

In a paper by Milli et al. 2025, algorithms targeting social media users would often overfeed them engagement-based content, in the case of their study, political posts, as opposed to content that the user had followed or sought out. Respondents in this same study also reported that the political posts they often saw made them feel worse about those of another political affiliation. These social media sites position their algorithms to feed content that keeps users engaged, even in instances where this content makes the user feel worse.

These three studies all establish different pieces of the same puzzle: social media sites track what their users do, can determine personal data from those users' interactions and feed them content that they will be more likely to interact with, even if this content is adversarial or damaging to the user. The ultimate goal for these companies is to have their users spend more time online, where they can be fed more ads and ultimately yield more profit.

1.2 Vulnerable Demographics

Gambling addiction is on the rise and in today's society is becoming a prevalent topic. A paper by Diana Moreira, Andreia Azeredo, and Paulo Dias (2023) collating multiple other studies finds that gamblers more prone to high-risk gambling are often younger men, who are single or married for a short period of time. They state that these men often live alone and are often in financial difficulties.

A paper by Krotter et al. (2024) interviewed approximately 2750 Spanish university students on their gambling habits, with an average age of approximately 19.5. Their findings align with the previous paper's conclusion that those most likely to gamble and be problem gamblers are men between the ages of 18-25.

In a paper by the Concurrent Disorders Society, the study polled underage youth on their gambling habits. The survey done in middle schools around Valencia, Spain, involved over 6000 students. Results showed that over half of the polled students had gambled at some point despite being underage and unable to legally gamble. Additionally, the rate of respondents with indicators of problem gambling was three times higher than in the general population. This paper, like the other two, found statistical significance in the gender gap between male and female youth who gambled and found that the most common type of gambling was online sports bets. (Chóliz & Marcos, 2022)

The first paper takes a broad approach, compiling data from multiple papers to reach its conclusions that some of the most vulnerable populations, while the second and third papers focus on first-person accounts of gambling activity across Spanish university and middle school students. The papers all present the same outcome that youth and young people are a demographic that is more likely to participate in gambling and be problem gamblers, often men at a higher rate than women.

1.3 Targeting of Vulnerable Groups

As established social media websites have algorithms designed to retain users and have them stay on the site, even when the content is displayed is detrimental or negative to the user. This holds true even when content is being recommended to demographics that

should not have access to it. A 2022 paper by Rossi & Nairn found that content promoting gambling was being pushed to youth at a high rate, and the content was often more enjoyable to a younger demographic. The paper references Rossi and Nairn's previous study from 2021, where 650 participants aged 11-78 provided ratings for how gambling ads made them feel. Younger respondents, aged 11-24, found these ads four times more appealing than older respondents. Additionally, eleven of the twelve ads shown triggered positive emotions in the younger group. (Rossi & Nairn, 2021) The 2022 paper concludes that social media gambling ads have increased in volume and that they target both adults and underage minors. They also find that the ads displayed often appear financially incentivising, but young demographics cannot fully comprehend the message of the advertisement relating to points like gambling odds. (Rossi & Nairn, 2022)

Establishing that social media is aware of who its users are, what their age and what they are interested in, it should be easy for minors not to be shown gambling-related content. However, as established, these algorithms will display content even if it has a negative effect on the user. This divide between what is good for a young social media user and what is shown to them is important to note and keep track of as this paper develops.

2. Social Media Advertisement Methods

2.1 Traditional Advertisement

Online casinos are now looking to expand their reach to a national or even international consumer base; their online model presents new opportunities for customer acquisition, and many companies are turning to celebrities to endorse their products. In some instances, celebrities will partner with online gambling sites. These celebrity partnerships use their star power to attract more players, and the celebrity may offer promotion beyond a simple advertisement. For example, rapper Snoop Dogg has a partnership with the online casino Roobet. The casino has since used his likeness extensively in advertisements and has released two slot machines themed after his persona and likeness. (Snoop Dogg, 2023)

Gambling sites' use of celebrity endorsement has led to an increase in user trust and a decrease in risk perception. In a 2024 paper, focus groups of Australian students were interviewed on their exposure to gambling marketing. Students provided a wide range of responses; some said that celebrity endorsement of gambling sites made them seem more legitimate, while others felt that celebrities were doing the ads for money with no consideration for what they endorse and who may see it. Some also felt that seeing social media influencers and celebrities who relate to a younger demographic made gambling look cool. (Pitt et al., 2024) In certain jurisdictions, such as Canada, it is forbidden to use celebrities in ads promoting gambling; however, gambling companies quickly pivoted to avoid this restriction by making "safe gambling ads" a promotion where a celebrity advertises how a particular gambling site promotes safe gambling and what limiter tools it offers. This "safe gambling ad," while it does not promote gambling, is still a clear example of promotion covered in branded colours, logos, and slogans to remind viewers about their gambling site. (Charlebois & Kelly, 2025)

While advertisement with celebrities is not a new idea for casinos it is a new territory. Historically, there would have been little benefit for having a celebrity promote a physical casino location; now, with the reach that virtual casinos offer, advertisements can be shown internationally to attract new customers, and by utilising celebrities, casinos can cultivate their desired image for themselves. Even in instances where the use of celebrity promotion is limited, the appeal that a celebrity offers to potential customers is so great that a casino will create an ad where the celebrity advertises safer gambling, something that ultimately would work against their business.

2.2 Gambling Influencers

Online gambling has also created new communities for gambling streams. Sites like Kick have created platforms for streamers to showcase their gambling sessions and habits. (Kick, 2025) Online casinos will partner with these streamers and offer them codes that they can pass on to their users to earn a commission. For example, the casino Stake offers the chance to become a “Stake Affiliate.” Affiliates can have users use their unique code, and they receive a cut of users' losses as they gamble. (Stake, 2025) These gambling creators don’t often portray a realistic idea of gambling and are incentivised by the cut they receive to have their followers gamble using the affiliate code. A notable example is the rapper Drake, who signed a 100 million dollar deal with the online casino Stake, in exchange for promotion through live streams and advertisements. On these streams, Drake would gamble and promote signing up to Stake, offering sign-up bonuses when you used his code. (Forbes, 2024)

Through the expansion of online gambling, these influencers have carved out a niche for themselves. Walking a line between gambling promotion and entertainment, these streamers will often portray wildly unrealistic examples of gambling content. One of the largest gambling streamers, who goes by the name XQC in September 2024 revealed that he has allegedly wagered over $3 billion dollars across 1.1 million bets on Stake casino. However, he revealed that over his 1.1 million bets, approximately 1 million have been losses. Mathematically, finding his average bet to be around $2750, it would amount to total losses of $2.75 billion. This absurd sum of money leads many online viewers to assume the funds he wagers with are fake and provided to him by Stake casino, and he is attempting to lure users into the casino for the affiliate money. (sportsskeeda, 2024)

2.3 Native Ads

Another branch of gambling content creators is centred around sports betting. Many creators on sites like Instagram will create content advertising their gambling bets, things like what players will do well, what teams they think will win, etc. These creators amass fan bases and often encourage their followers to copy their bets. However, there are instances where these creators are sponsored by a gambling site, and creators make what is referred to as a native ad. A native ad is an advertisement that seeks to match and emulate its surroundings to present a subtle message. (hostadvice, 2025) A popular well well-known example is the company Red Bull and the stunts they perform, while not specifically an advertisement, there is branding that keeps the name prevalent. (Red Bull, 2025) In instances of social media sports betting content, a creator may promote a specific betting site to place this bet on or provide a link to their profile on the website. In a study by Ulster University, participants who engage with sports content had their Instagrams examined, and it was found that often they

would also receive sports gambling content that related to betting. (Bidav et al., 2024) While it is not always possible to determine if a post is a paid advertisement, the adjacency of sports and sports betting allows for an easy transition to betting content, which in instances is a disguised ad

Native ads are the newest way in which gambling companies attempt to recruit new users. Given the structure of social media content considered adjacent to existing interests, often indistinguishable from a normal social media feed, these ads subtly advertise to viewers while not outwardly declaring themselves as an advertisement.

3. Cultural Normalisation

3.1 Merging of Sport and Betting

In a 2021 paper from Australia, 111 participants aged 11-16 were surveyed and asked their opinion on the normalisation of gambling. A majority of respondents replied saying they perceived betting on sports to be normal and something everyone does. Other participants challenged the idea that sport and betting should be linked with gambling, but did accept that its normality was on the rise despite their personal objections. The respondents reported hearing older individuals discuss who would win upcoming matches for gambling purposes and the female respondents found gambling on sports even more acceptable. (Nyemcsok et al., 2021)

In a study based in Australia, a poll of approximately 800 people was conducted and asked to provide their personal demographics and their gambling behaviour. Additionally, they were asked to provide a list of the twenty most influential people in their lives, referred to as alters, and report the same data, as well as their relation to the primary interviewee. Results that were returned indicated that participants who were problem gamblers were often in relationships with other people who fell into the category of problem gamblers. The study finds that those in close groups with their alters allow for problematic gambling habits to be normalised through community elements. (Russel, Langham & Hing, 2018)

Both these studies indicate that through socialised gambling interaction, the negatives and downsides are negated and not discussed; in essence, an echo chamber, ignoring the negatives of gambling, is created by social circles that gamble or don't gamble. While some respondents in both papers object to the notion that gambling is normal, they do accept that on a societal level, gambling on sport is becoming more and more common.

3.2 Event-Based Gambling

In a 2025 paper by Health Promotion International, viewers of the recent EURO 2024 Cup were asked to recall if they saw any advertisements about gambling and if they impacted their gambling habits during EURO 2024. The paper hypothesizes that the frequent gambling communications created an illusion of control, a gambler's fallacy, where a gambler believes that they can control an outcome, in this case, win a bet. In an issued survey, respondents were asked to recall what formats they saw gambling promotion, with 53.6% recalling seeing gambling promotion content on social media. This is also potentially indicative of an instance of native ads, as in Belgium, where the survey was issued,

sponsored social media promotion from gambling companies is not allowed. Additionally, 55% of respondents admitted they gambled more than they would on average over the course of the EURO Cup. (Jacobs et al., 2025) Another instance of heightened event gambling is the Super Bowl. In a 2025 news article, The Independent reported that Americans alone would be wagering $1.39 billion USD. (The Independent, 2025) Which per, New York Post is a record amount. (New York Post, 2025)

Both of these significant spotting events garner worldwide attention and subsequently attract large amounts of gambling. However, even non-significant games are garnering increased attention. It's estimated that for the current NFL season, Americans will wager $30 billion. In a 272-game NFL season, this represents approximately $110 million USD wagered on each contest. This total is an 8.5% increase over the previous year's estimated $27.6 billion USD. (American Gaming Association, 2025)

The quantity of sports bets is increasing, and as established in 3.1, sports and betting are becoming more and more intertwined in the public's eyes. With total betting increasing year over year the unification of gambling and watching sports increases while sportsbooks stand to make larger profits. Assuming an approximately 5% profit margin for sportsbooks on all wagers placed, only on the NFL market, companies would reach a $1.5 billion profit.

Conclusion

Through my research, I have identified the competencies of social media algorithms and how attuned and specific they can be, identifying multiple intimate traits about users and feeding them content that would fall under their interests to keep them engaged. Identifying youth as being susceptible to problem gambling, and also identifying that social media will still feed these young people content relating to gambling. Through various methods of advertising, such as celebrity partnerships, native ads or social media influencers, we can see that gambling content to be shown on social media platforms is plentiful and oftentimes subtle and misleading. Additionally, on a societal level, sport is becoming ever more intertwined with the act of sport betting wagers, with the amount of funds wagered year over year continuing to rise. Exploiting naive, inexperienced youth, gambling sites seek to continue recruiting new users to keep profiting off everyday people's losses.

A key gap I identified in my research is the area of how specific gambling ads can become. Existing research triggered by algorithmic prompts is understudied. One of the largest research gaps exists in the idea of gambling companies manipulating their advertisement to cater on an extremely individual basis with the immense wealth of knowledge that social media has on its users.

While the idea of gambling normalisation exists and gambling has become more commonplace and accepted, gambling companies continue to push for more acceptance to make gambling commonplace in society, showing ads where gambling is done socially with friends or the implication that you couldn’t watch a sports game without placing monetary bets on it.

One of the largest gaps in available studies is that, on a societal scale, we are moving towards an ultimate gambling normalisation where you can gamble on everything. The newest form of gambling currently gaining popularity is called prediction markets. The company Kalshi allows users to bet on either side of almost any outcome, with a recent bet hosted by the company being the New York mayoral race. The co-founder of the gambling site has stated that his ultimate goal is to “financialise everything and create a tradeable asset out of any difference of opinion.” - Tarek Mansour, 2025 (Gizmodo, 2025)

Our society is beginning to reach a turning point where anything can be bet on, anytime, from anywhere. While I disagree with the idea that gambling is a taboo practice, there is an immense gap between being able to not bet at all and being able to bet on absolutely everything. Despite all the advancements gambling companies have made, they will continue to push for more until society pushes back.

The easiest place to face the issues is to begin with the youth who are so heavily affected. Education and policy changes are crucial, and ensuring that young people understand that gambling is not an activity that everyone partakes in is the easiest first step that can be made. Providing tools that show people the consequences of gambling, the losses they will incur and the consequences they open themselves up to. To address this gap, I plan to investigate legislative changes that have been applied successfully in other regions and see how they could be applied in a consistent, loophole-free way.

Appendix A

Themes	Article	Summary	Relevance	Connections to other literature
Social Media and Vulnerable Demographics	1.1 A Engagement, user satisfaction, and the amplification of divisive content on social media (Milli et al, 2025)	A paper that outlines how social media-recommended content will take over a user's timeline as opposed to their selected content	Relevant to topic 1.1 - to display how aggressive social media algorithms can become	Complementary to 1.1 B indicates how social algorithms will disperse content
	1.1 B Uncovering the Interaction Equation (Habib et al., 2024)	A paper analysing specific user actions and their results on Twitter recommended content feed	Relevant to topic 1.1 - provides information on social media algorithms operations	Complementary to 1.1 A indicates how social algorithms will disperse content
	1.1 C Private traits and attributes are predictable from digital records of human behaviour (Kosinski, Stillwell, Graepel, 2013)	A tracking model that can identify personal traits of Facebook users by their liked content	Relevant to topic 1.1 - displays how accurate profiles of users can be made with user data	Minimal connections to other literature
	1.2 A Risk Factors for Gambling Disorder: A Systematic Review (Moreira, Azeredo, Dias, 2023)	Identifies young men as being at risk of developing problem gambling habits	Relevant to topic 1.2 - displays a group vulnerable to problem gambling	Complementary to 1.2 B and C identifies a similar vulnerable demographic
	1.2 B Risk Factors of At-Risk/Problem	Identifies young Spanish university students, young men, as being at risk of developing	Relevant to topic 1.2 - displays a group vulnerable to problem gambling	Complementary to 1.2 A and C identifies a similar vulnerable

	Gambling Among Young Adult Spanish Students (Krotter et al., 2024)	problem gambling habits		demographic
	1.2 C That's No Country for 'Young' Men'': A Critical Perspective on Responsible Online Gambling Policies for Gambling Disorder Prevention in Spanish Minors (Chóliz & Marcos, 2022)	Interviewed Spanish middle schoolers and identified gambling issues within the population	Relevant to topic 1.2 - displays a group vulnerable to problem gambling and displays that the group extends into minors	Complementary to 1.2 A and B identifies a similar vulnerable demographic
	1.3 A New Developments in Gambling Marketing: the Rise of Social Media Ads and Its Effect on Youth (Rossi & Nairn, 2022)	Indicates how ads can target youth and those who should not be able to see them, while referencing youths' heightened enjoyment of the ads	Indicates that ads may be targeted at younger demographics	References 1.3 B a previous study by the same authors
	1.3 B What are the odds? The appeal of gambling adverts to children and young persons on twitter (Rossi & Nairn, 2021)	The process of a quantitative survey indicates that gambling ads are more appealing to a younger demographic	Indicates that ads may be targeted at younger demographics	Parent study to 1.3 A
Social Media Advertisement Methods	2.1 A Snoop Dogg X Roobet (Snoop Dogg, 2023)	Page that outlines Snoop Dogg's partnership with online casino Roobet	Proof of partnership	Minimal relation to other content

	2.1 B Protecting Canada's youth from the risks of exposure to gambling advertising (Charlebois & Kelly, 2025)	Indicates Canada's restrictions on celebrity use in gambling ads as well as gambling companies' ways to circumvent this legislation	Indicates a countries attempt at controlling gambling advertisement while also display how companies may work around it	Minimal Relation
	2.1 C Young people's views about the use of celebrities and social media influencers in gambling marketing (Pitt et al., 2024)	Interviewed Australian students for their stances on the use of celebrities in gambling advertisements. Some students found it relatable while others were against it	Gets a youth group opinion on celebrity use and identifies if they are swayed by celebrity usage	Minimal relation. Compliments 2.1 B
	2.2 A Live Stream on Kick (Kick, 2025)	Proof of Website Kick	Platform known for gambling influencer streams	Minimal relation
	2.2 B Affiliate Program Stake.com (Stake, 2025)	Proof of Stake's affiliate program	Displays a template for online casino affiliate programs. Similar systems are used by other companies.	Minimal Relation
	2.2 C Drake Proves 'Nothing Was The Same' After Conquering Crypto (Forbes, 2024)	Provides a profile of the rapper Drake, who moved into the online streaming gambling space	Drake is a high-profile celebrity who used his influence to pull people into Stake casino	Minimal relation Compliments 2.2 D
	2.2 D xQc reveals he wagered over $2.9 billion while gambling on Stake (sportsskeeda, 2024)	Provides a profile of the streamer xQc, a prominent figure in the online gambling space	xQc offers a look at the unrealistic picture painted by gambling influencers with his unrealistic losses	Minimal relation Compliments 2.2 C

	2.3 A What Is Native Advertising & How It Works? (+ Examples & Tips) (hostadvice, 2025)	Provides the definition of native advertising	Defines Native Advertising	Compliments 2.3 B and C to define native advertising
	2.3 B Red Bull Energy Drink (Red Bull, 2025)	Red Bull company homepage	Provides an example of Native advertising	Compliments 2.3 A and C to provide a well-known example of native advertising
	2.3 C Connecting With Sports Fans: Gambling Marketing Strategies on Instagram (Bidav et al., 2024)	Outlines a study where focus groups on Instagram were studied. Users began at sport-related content, that that Instagram algorithm eventually moved into gambling content	Indicates how algorithms move users into recommended content that promotes gambling	Compliments 2.3 A and B by displaying how native ads take effect
Cultural Normalisation	3.1 A Social influences normalize gambling-related harm among higher-risk gamblers (Russel, Langham & Hing, 2018)	Outlines how in social communities that both do and do not gamble, problem gamblers can end up in an “echo chamber” where their problematic gambling habits are downplayed	Displays how gambling has become normalised and even those in your immediate circle who do not gamble cannot recognize problematic gambling practices	Compliments 3.1 B
	3.1 B Young people's reflections on the factors contributing to the normalisation of gambling in Australia (Nyemcsok et al., 2021)	Interviews of young Australian students who provide opinions on the normalisation of gambling. Covering a spectrum of indifference to distaste. However, all agree that despite their personal feelings,s gambling has become normalised	Gets the opinion of young Australian students on their stances of gambling normalisation.	Compliments 3.1 A
	3.2 A AGA estimates $30 Billion in Legal Wagering on 2025 NFL Season	Outlines estimated wagers for the 2025 NFL season	Indicates the volume of finds placed on sportsbook wagers	Compliments 3.2 D showcasing the quantity of funds wagered on sporting events

	(American Gaming Association, 2025)			
	3.2 B Record amount to be wagered on Super Bowl 20255 (New York Post, 2025)	Explains the record-breaking amount wagered on Super Bowl 2025	Indicates the volume of finds placed on sportsbook wagers	Compliments 3.2 D showcasing quantity of funds wagered on significant sporting events
	3.2 C America is expected to bet $1.4 billion on the Super Bowl. Many will be placed by a growing number of gambling addicts (The Independent, 2025)	Outlines estimated wagers for the 2025 NFL Super Bowl	Outlines an estimate	Compliments 3.2 D showcasing quantity of funds wagered on significant sporting events
	3.2 D Shaping the odds: gambling communication normalized betting and fostered illusions of control during EURO 2024 (Jacobs et al., 2025)	Explains the Gambling habits of EURO Cup 2024 watchers. Indicates gambler fallacies of illusion of control and how often others gamble. Also outlines how, during the EURO Cup 2024 gamblers wagered above their usual spend	Indicates how gamblers will exceed their spend for major sporting events and will fall into gambler's fallacies to justify their wagers	Complemented by 3.2 A/B/C